OTT

IMAGINING THE UNDERWORLD

Jaideep Ahlawat is back headlining a new season of *Paatal Lok*, the show that catapulted him into the limelight



Ahlawat with Gul Panag

For Jaideep Ahlawat, life can be divided into two halves: before May 15, 2020, and after it. That's when Season 1 of the Amazon Prime Video show *Paatal Lok* released and viewers finally witnessed the range of his thespian skills, spread across nearly eight hours of compelling storytelling. "Be it the kind of scripts that came my way to my approach towards them, everything changed," says Ahlawat, who until then was best known for an effective supporting turn in *Raazi* (2018). "People trusted me to anchor stories, and responsibility and expectations increased." He wasn't the only beneficiary of the critically acclaimed and audience-beloved show. Its creator and showrunner Sudip Sharma became a sought-after writer, co-director Avinash Arun got to develop his own show, and actor Ishwak Singh got noticed as did Abhishek Banerjee as the menacing dog-loving killer, Hathoda Tyagi.

The stakes are expectedly high from Season 2, which released on January 17. Ahlawat and Ishwak reprise their khaki-clad characters of Hathi Ram Chaudhary and Imran Ansari, respectively, and Arun is back in the director's chair. Sharma fast forwards to two years, but this time, apart from the capital, he takes the story to Nagaland. "Nagaland has this very rich, complex history. It's a part of India about which we know so little and speak so little," says Sharma, who grew up and went to school in Guwahati. "Through Hathi Ram's eyes, I want to go back to places that I have a strong connection to. If there's ever a third season, I want to take it west, like Rajasthan, where my family's roots are."

Also thrilled to be back is Gul Panag, who plays Hathi Ram's wife Renu, who will be more "empowered" in the second outing. Having recently re-watched Season 1, Panag felt the show redefined the crime thriller genre by centring it on a regular, by-the-rule inspector. That Sharma had managed to make an authentic police show while touching on pertinent socio-political issues like class disparity, caste prejudice, religious bigotry, social injustice, mental health and more, made *Paatal Lok* all the



JAIDEEP AHLAWAT says people started trusting him to anchor stories, and responsibility and expectations increased after *Paatal Lok*'s success